

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Sandalwood Limb"

Ārya-candanāṅga-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 857 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཙན་ག་ཕྱིན་ལག་ཅས་བརྒྱུའི་གཟུངས།

The Sandalwood Limb (Candanāṅga) is a short dhāraṇī text whose Sanskrit title is Ārya-candanāṅga-nāma-dhāraṇī and whose Tibetan title is Phagpa Tsendän gyi Yenlak ches jawé Zungs, rendered in English as "The Noble Dhāraṇī called 'The Sandalwood Limb.'" Set in Rājagṛha, where the Buddha addresses a large assembly of monks, bodhisattvas, and gods, it presents a dhāraṇī, a protective formula of spoken power, spoken by the Blessed One and directed in part to the bodhisattvas Avalokiteśvara and Candraprabha. It belongs to the genre of dhāraṇī literature, in which such formulas are taught together with their benefits and the way they are to be used. In the canon, it is Toh 857 in the Kangyur, and it is classed among the Tantra division.

The Exposition. In the language of India: Ārya-candanāṅga-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī called "The Sandalwood Limb." Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in Rājagṛha together with a great assembly of monks, a great assembly of monks numbering twelve thousand five hundred, and with a great many bodhisattvas, great beings, and also with many distinguished gods.

Then the Blessed One, upon the seat that had been prepared, sat blazing and radiant, resplendent through the Tathāgata's miraculous power. Then the Blessed One addressed, in that assembly, the bodhisattva, the great being Avalokiteśvara, and Candraprabha, who had become a youth, saying: "Sons of noble family, beyond this world-realm, and farther still beyond it, past worlds numerous as the grains of sand in as many Ganges rivers as there are billions, trillions, and hundreds of thousands of billions, there is a world-realm called Glory of Sandalwood. There the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Sandalwood Limb lives and abides even now, and teaches the Dharma. All the beings of that world-realm are, without exception, irreversible. Having heard this foundation of the dhāraṇī, the knowledge-mantra called Sandalwood Limb, which that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete Buddha Sandalwood Limb taught for the sake of all beings, those who are irreversible are freed from evil and never separate from the awakening mind.

The Blessed Ones, the Tathāgata Amitāyus, the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara, the Tathāgata Vairocana, and other buddhas, Blessed Ones of the past, also taught it long ago. I too shall teach it to you. In order to look after all beings, listen well and attend carefully.

In the later age, in the last of the five hundred years, when the sacred Dharma is perishing, there will arise those who are entirely without Dharma: those who commit the deeds of immediate retribution, those who revile the sacred Dharma, those who destroy stūpas, those who steal and plunder the property of the Saṅgha, those who falsely claim to be renunciants when they are not, and those who abandon their preceptors and masters. In order to protect them, I shall teach this basis of the dhāraṇī-mantra of the Sandalwood Limb, blessed by all the buddhas. Bodhisattvas, listen to me."

Then the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and Candraprabha, who had become a youth, bowed their heads at the two feet of the Blessed One and made their request: "Out of compassion for the bodhisattvas, the great beings, and for billions upon billions and hundreds of thousands of other beings, and in order that evil may be purified, may the Blessed One teach it. May the Sugata teach it. May the Tathāgata teach it. We too shall take up these bases of the dhāraṇī-mantra and shall expound them extensively and correctly for the sake of all beings."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Tadyathā: cirāte, marīcike, durdame, durdānte, duranupraviṣṭe, candanāṃ gaje, samantaparisoḍhani, viśuddhaśīle, caritravati, ancedyapratibhāne, sarvabuddhādhiṣṭite, bhagavate, pāpakṣaye, āśāṃ e paripūraya svāhā.

"Whatever sons of good family or daughters of good family uphold, recite, teach, or fully realize these bases of the great dhāraṇī-mantra, in this very life their eyes will become perfectly pure. As soon as they hear it, they will be fully liberated from evil. They will be blessed by all the bodhisattvas, and they will also see the form of the Tathāgata. If they practice recitation for half a month, they will see the noble Avalokiteśvara, the Lord, and Candraprabha, the Youthful One. Even the evil deeds of the five boundless crimes will be purified. They will remember their births. After passing from this life, they will be born among the gods, or born into the households of great, prosperous householders. All beings will be delighted by them.

It may happen that this entire great earth crumbles. The ocean may dry up. Likewise the king of mountains, Mount Meru (Sumeru), may be destroyed. The wind may be bound with a rope. The moon and the sun may fall to the ground. Space may be pressed down with two hands. Fire may turn into water. The four great elements may become something else. The minds of all sentient beings may become one. Yet what the Tathāgata has spoken and blessed can never become otherwise; no one can move or shake it. The evil Māra will find no opening against it."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Avalokiteśvara, paid homage to the Blessed One and said: "Blessed One, I too shall teach the ritual procedure of this dhāraṇī. In front of a stūpa of the Dharma King containing relics, or in front of an image of the Buddha, make a maṇḍala of white sandalwood. Scatter loose flowers and perfume the place with sandalwood incense. From the second day of the month until the fifteenth, bathe three times each day and change one's clothes three times. One should offer food and burnt offerings, and keep the restoration vow (poṣadha), with an even-minded attitude toward all beings. On the full-moon day, keep a fast for a day and a night. Stay upon a mat of grass, lie down on a spread of grass, and recite single-pointedly, scattering fragrant flowers a hundred thousand times. Then the ground will tremble. One will see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha, and Avalokiteśvara. As soon as one hears the great dhāraṇī, one will obtain whatever one desires. One will also come to retain what one has heard. And all karmic obscurations will be purified."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the monks, those bodhisattvas, that entire assembly, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced, and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the dhāraṇī called "The Noble Sandalwood Limb."

It was translated, revised, and finalized under the new terminology by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the great reviser-translator, the venerable Yeshé Dé.

Translator's Notes

- The mantra is given in a normalized Sanskrit rendering of the Tibetan transcription; several syllables are corrupt in the Tibetan and are uncertain. "Twelve thousand five hundred" translates khri nyis stong lnga brgya, which is literally twelve thousand five hundred. The phrase "sat blazing and radiant" renders a three-part Tibetan mimetic expression (lhams me, lhan ne, lhang nger) for brilliant splendor. The "foundation" or "basis" of the dhāraṇī-mantra

• The Tibetan "འགྲོ་བཞིན་སྐྱེད་པའི་རྒྱལ་ཁབ་ཀྱི་མཆོད་པོ།" is rendered "Candraprabha, the Youthful One," following the usual identification of the name as Candraprabhakumārabhūta; this is a conjectural reconstruction. The colophon's final phrase, "འགྲོ་བཞིན་སྐྱེད་པའི་རྒྱལ་ཁབ་ཀྱི་མཆོད་པོ།", is cut off in the source and is taken to refer to the revision according to the new (post-reform) terminology. In the ritual passage, the Tibetan text is somewhat elliptical; the grammatical subject shifts between the practitioner and Avalokiteśvara's speech, and I have rendered the instructions as general directions.

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May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.